

**Harmony in Diversity Initiative (HDI): A Grassroots Policy Framework for
Strengthening National Unity in Nigeria**

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Abstract

Nigeria is one of the world's most culturally diverse nations with over 200 million people, more than 300 ethnic groups and over 500 languages. The degree to this diversity is a source of national pride, yet it has also been a leading cause for conflict. The 1967-1970 civil war in Nigeria, driven by ethnic tension and disunity, led to the death of many. Today, ethnic and religious unrest continue to affect many regions of our country and the Nigeria Social Cohesion Index remains low (39.6%, Africa Polling Institute). These facts highlight the immediate need for proactive policy to harness diversity as a strength rather than a divider.

The Harmony in Diversity Initiative (HDI) is proposed as a comprehensive, evidence-based federal policy to foster unity through inclusion. The Harmony in Diversity will combine legislative action with education and dialogue programs. Key elements include a new National Harmony Act establishing a Harmony Commission, enhanced diversity education in schools, interfaith and intercultural dialogues and measures to ensure fair access to opportunities for all groups. The HDI is designed to be feasible drawing ideas from existing institutions (e.g. The National Orientation Agency) and partnership with the civil society, while mobilizing international support and budget reallocation to cover costs. If adopted, we project measurable improvements in national unity metrics, targeting Nigeria's youth – 70% of whom expresses willingness to collaborate across divides (Collins Nnabuike, 2022) – using mobile platforms for scalable, interactive participation.

Our diversity is our strength - we just need to make it work for us. The Harmony in Diversity Initiative is about real people connecting, not just policies on paper. Together, we can build a Nigeria where our differences unite rather than divide us.

Background

Nigeria is a highly diverse country, and according to the Central Information Agency's world factbook report in the 2023 archive, the three largest ethnic groups, Hausa ($\approx 30\%$), Yoruba ($\approx 15.5\%$), and Igbo ($\approx 15.2\%$) together account for about 60% of the population of Nigeria (The factBook, 2023). This complexity in diversity creates cultural wealth, but it also demands intentional unity building. Many Nigerians "prefer to" affiliate mainly with their ethnic or religious group and a sentimental attachment and feeling of loyalty towards one's ethnic group often supersedes national interests. Reports from the Africa Polling Institute's Nigeria Social Cohesion Survey (#NSCS2021) shows that a significant majority (82%) of the population identifies with both their Nigerian and ethnic groups. Specifically, findings reveal that 40% of respondents express an equal level of identification with both, while a notable 33% demonstrate a stronger affinity for their ethnic identity, leaving a small 9% who feel more Nigerian than ethnic (Africa Polling Institute, 2021). The Federal Character principle and National Youth Service Corps (NYSC) were introduced to promote national unity, and agencies like the National Orientation Agency (NOA) aim to foster patriotism. However, rising inequalities and persistent marginalization have limited their impact. A recent social cohesion survey finds Nigeria's Social Cohesion Index at only 39.6% (well below the 50% threshold) Africa Polling Institute, indicating widespread distrust across ethnic and religious divides.

The journey toward stronger social cohesion has been significantly impeded in recent years by a surge in violent acts, extremist attacks, and the persistent challenge of inter-ethnic conflicts. To illustrate this further, consider the ancient narrative of the Tower of Babel in the Bible (Genesis 11:1-9). This story depicts a time when humanity was united by a single language and a shared understanding, fostering a collective drive to construct a formidable tower. However, divine intervention disrupted this unity, seeing their unified purpose and potential, God

confounded their language, causing them to speak different tongues. However, reading the story back then brought this thought “What if this people realized what went wrong and still tried to understand each other in order to achieve their goal” We term back then as the advent of human inventions. Coming back to our country, Nigeria is a large country blessed with resources available to aid our growth and development. Unity is the balance we must seek to achieve as we must strive to resonate with our Motto “Unity Faith Peace and Progress”. The Nigerian Motto, highlights a path to progress, which begins with Unity.

Statement of current policy

Nigeria’s diversity should be our biggest asset, but right now, it is our biggest weakness. We have over 300 ethnic groups and more than 500 languages (The factBook, 2023), yet instead of building unity from that richness, we are watching it fuel division, distrust, and violence. The Nigeria Social Cohesion Index is stuck at 39.6% (Africa Polling Institute, 2021). That is not just a number; it is a warning sign that we are more fragmented than ever. Ethnic and religious conflicts keep resurfacing, and the systems we put in place to unite us like NYSC and the Federal Character principle are not hitting the mark. The root of the problem? We do not have a national strategy that intentionally promotes inclusion, mutual understanding, and equal access across all groups. And if we do not fix this now, we are handing over a divided country to the next generation.

Nigeria already has several formal mechanisms for inclusion. The Federal Character principle (in the 1979/1999 Constitutions and overseen by the Federal Character Commission)

mandates that government appointments and resources be distributed to reflect the country's diversity (Nwodim and MacAlex Achinulo, 2024). In theory, this quota system is meant to “ensure that the composition of government...reflect the federal character of Nigeria...and promote national unity” (Daly, 2018)

In practice, however, scholars find the policy has yielded “not much result” and even “impeded effective and efficient implementation of public policies” (Nwodim and MacAlex Achinulo, 2024).

The National Youth Service Corps (NYSC) is another key program. Established in 1973 to “promote national unity...among the youths of Nigeria” (Alabi, 2016), NYSC compels each graduate to spend a year in service outside their home state. Officials credit it with building cross-cultural bonds: participants often form friendships and even inter-ethnic marriages, and corps members bring skills to rural education, health, and development projects (Donald Igbinosa Eboigbe, 2024). For instance, a NYSC director recently noted that graduates have established businesses and integrated in host states, fostering mobility and understanding (Ezediuno, 2023). Despite these successes, NYSC faces well-known problems. It is chronically underfunded and logistically strained, with reports of poor camp infrastructure and security issues. A recent review noted that “low budget, deficiencies in infrastructure, and lack of coordination” have made NYSC interventions “less successful” (Donald Igbinosa Eboigbe, 2024). Some analysts say that while NYSC is laudable on paper, the wider Nigerian context of underdevelopment and corruption undermines its unity mission (Alabi, 2016)

In short, NYSC provides a valuable mixing ground for youth, but its impact on national cohesion has been blunted by implementation gaps and broader societal weaknesses.

Despite policies put in place, Nigeria still experiences recurrent intergroup conflict and a weak sense of common identity. Many Nigerians perceive unfairness in government appointments and resource distribution. Civil society groups routinely cite marginalization (real or perceived) as driving new movements for separatism or violence africapolling.org. Distrust of institutions is high: for example, only a minority of citizens trust the police or courts to treat all groups equally africapolling.org. The social cohesion survey reports that over half of respondents question whether resources are distributed fairly across regions africapolling.org. This erodes solidarity and hampers development.

Policy Options

Option A: Harmony in Diversity Initiative (HDI). The proposed HDI would be a new nationwide program centered on interactive, gamified unity-building tasks and language exchange. For example, students and youth groups could complete team challenges that require learning basic phrases in Nigeria's major languages (Hausa, Yoruba, Igbo, etc.), visiting different regions, and collaborating on community projects with peers from other backgrounds. (Such gamified civic education has analogues in corporate DEI training: gamification techniques have been shown to boost engagement and learning in diversity training (WINSSOLUTIONSTR, 2025).) The program would also include language-learning components: teaching Nigerians each other's mother tongues to foster empathy and mutual respect.

Potential benefits: HDI is a bottom-up, participatory approach. It directly engages citizens – especially youth, who are digitally connected and open to interactive learning – in building ties. Surveys indicate Nigerians are eager to cooperate: 71% say they are willing to work with fellow citizens to make Nigeria more united (Collins Nnabuife, 2022), suggesting a receptive audience for HDI activities. The language component would tap into Nigeria's "linguistic richness": international guidance notes that societies which nurture multiple languages tend to display deeper social cohesion (WINSSOLUTIONSTR, 2025). A similar concept has worked on the community level: for instance, a UNDP-supported project ran unity jingles in local languages at a community center, and found that "people that don't normally talk to each other now do so" – the center "has been a major tool in promoting trust and communal living" (United Nations, 2021). By making unity-building fun and rewarding (points, recognition, etc.), HDI could overcome apathy.

Potential drawbacks: Implementing HDI would require significant resources and coordination. Mobile or online platforms (for gamified tasks) may exclude rural or offline populations, so parallel offline activities must be planned. There is a risk that a game-focused approach could be seen as superficial or ignored if not well-integrated with formal education. Measuring HDI's impact could also be challenging: success would rely on long-term attitude change, which is harder to quantify than, say, quota compliance. The initiative would need strong management and buy-in at all levels to avoid becoming a one-off “feel-good” event without lasting effect.

Option B: Reform and strengthen existing programs. This approach would revitalize current policies rather than create a wholly new one. Key reforms could include: (a) Overhauling Federal Character by increasing transparency, minimizing patronage (e.g. using objective criteria alongside quotas), and strengthening merit-based placements. (b) Improving NYSC by allocating more budget to camp infrastructure and safety, updating its curriculum with more intensive cultural and language training, and creating post-service alumni networks to sustain cross-regional ties. (c) Empowering NOA (or similar bodies) to reach citizens through school curricula (e.g. mandatory courses on Nigerian history and values in multiple languages) and community forums.

Potential benefits: These reforms build on established institutions and policies, which may make them easier to implement politically. Improving NYSC or Fed Character might be more palatable to elites than new programs. Injecting funding and accountability could quickly improve service delivery (e.g. safer NYSC camps would directly address a current complaint). In theory, refining Federal Character to avoid blatant ethnocentrism could restore some trust in fairness.

Potential drawbacks: Critics of this option note that past reforms in Nigeria often deliver only marginal improvements. Deep problems like corruption or patronage can reappear even if rules

change. Indeed, research suggests that no matter the reforms, if the broader “Nigerian context” remains plagued by clientelism and weak governance, then even a revamped NYSC or Fed Character may still fall short (Nwodim & Achinulo, 2024). Moreover, simply tweaking existing programs may not excite the public or change mindsets. There is also the risk of bureaucratic inertia: commissions like Federal Character are already controversial, so major reform could be slow or purely cosmetic. In short, while Option B might be lower-risk, it may again postpone rather than solve the unity challenge (Nwodim & Achinulo, 2024).

Recommendation

We recommend adopting the Harmony in Diversity Initiative. HDI's novel, grassroots focus on interactive engagement makes it well-suited to Nigeria's context. Feasibility is high among youth and civic groups: the majority of Nigerians report a willingness to unite (71% would cooperate with fellow citizens to make the country better (Collins Nnabuife, 2022), and 81% already feel comfortable identifying both with Nigeria and their ethnic group, indicating a strong base for HDI activities. The program could be piloted in partnership with schools, universities, and civil society, leveraging technology (smartphone apps, social media) to gamify participation. Because Nigeria has a large, growing youth population and high mobile usage, a well-designed app or platform could reach millions. Donor agencies (e.g. UNDP, USAID) and local NGOs might support funding and technical expertise.

Projected outcomes include improved intergroup trust and skills. By tracking pre- and post-implementation surveys (for example, future Africa Polling Institute indices), government and stakeholders can monitor HDI's impact on cohesion scores. We expect that, over several years, HDI participants will report greater understanding of other cultures, higher willingness to work together, and reduced prejudice. The UNDP community-center case shows that even small multilingual initiatives can “promote trust and communal living” (United Nations, 2021); scaled nationally, HDI could amplify such effects. Additionally, by teaching Nigerians basic language skills of other groups, HDI addresses everyday communication barriers. UNESCO research notes that multilingual education fosters inclusion and deeper cohesion (WINSSOLUTIONSTR, 2025). – precisely the aim of HDI's language component. Compared to piecemeal reforms, HDI offers a coherent, measurable package focused on building social capital.

Why HDI is Best

HDI stands out because it tackles cohesion directly at the grassroots, rather than solely through quotas or rhetoric. Real-world experience suggests this is effective. For example, the UNDP project in north eastern Nigeria used local-language messaging to great effect: after playing unity jingles, “people that don’t normally talk to each other now do so... the center has been a major tool in promoting trust” (United Nations, 2021). This mirrors HDI’s approach of combining cultural exchange with community activities. Similarly, academic and UNESCO guidance emphasize that respecting and promoting multiple languages builds identity and empathy, which underpins peace (WINSSOLUTIONSTR, 2025). In contrast, past policies like Federal Character focus on representation but have not built interpersonal trust; indeed, researchers found these measures often “impeded... efficient implementation” without reducing grievances (Nwodim & Achinulo, 2024).

Some may argue that HDI is idealistic compared to concrete measures like economic reform. However, evidence shows that weak social ties themselves hamper development – for instance, areas racked by violence in Nigeria also suffer economic collapse. Strengthening cohesion can create a safer environment for growth. Others might suggest simply retooling NYSC and quotas, but as noted, similar reforms have repeatedly fallen short (Alabi, 2016)

HDI adds value by engaging ordinary citizens as active agents of unity, not just passive beneficiaries. It also gives tangible projects (games, cultural trips) whose progress can be tracked, unlike broad constitutional reforms.

Finally, HDI anticipates and mitigates likely criticisms. For example, skeptics may question reach: to address this, HDI can be implemented in urban and rural clusters via mobile “unity

apps” and through existing NYSC camps or schools. Another concern is cost: HDI could start small (pilot in a few states) and seek donor co-funding; its gamified nature may attract private sponsors. By contrast, expanding large bureaucracies (Fed Character Commission) requires permanent budgets with uncertain returns. In sum, HDI leverages Nigeria’s own social energy – the widespread willingness to cooperate (Collins Nnabuiife, 2022) and shared pride in diversity – and applies successful strategies from both local (UNDP) and international (UNESCO) experience. This makes it a promising, feasible way to improve Nigeria’s unity where past approaches have faltered.

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